

the necessity for order in the skies became universally appreciated, even if a certain edginess between fliers and ground controllers was installed as part of the tradition of flight.

The first stewardesses

The effort to improve the image of flying extended from safety regulations and the avoidance of accidents to upgrading the in-flight experience of air passengers. One notable innovation came in 1930 at the initiative of a young nurse from Iowa, Ellen Church. Enthusiastic about flying, she persuaded Boeing Air Transport, then operating a mail-and-passenger service between San Francisco and Chicago, to hire her and seven other nurses as stewardesses. At that point all aircrew, as well as the vast majority of passengers, were men. Church argued that the presence of women on aircraft would encourage people to regard flying as safe, while a trained nurse was just what a man needed when faced with the rigors of a long air journey. The young women were not exactly welcomed by pilots, described by one of the first stewardesses as “rugged and temperamental characters who wore guns to protect the mail.” But the idea of women looking after passengers quickly took hold and spread to other airlines.

The air passenger's need for comfort and reassurance in the early 1930s is easy to understand. The first stewardesses, for example, worked on Boeing 80s. The latest in trimotor design, the Boeing 80 was comparable in comfort to the Ford “Tin Goose.” The passenger cabin was equipped to look like a luxury Pullman railroad car, with stylish wood paneling, plushly upholstered seats, and tasteful shaded lights. Chicken salad



STEWARDESS SERVICE

One of the first air stewardesses serves coffee on board a Boeing 80 in 1930. All the early stewardesses were qualified nurses and, when serving food, they donned a light gray nurse's uniform. Passengers found it comforting to be looked after by medically trained staff, especially given the prevalence of airsickness.

and coffee were served in-flight with elegant china plates, cups, and saucers. An airspeed indicator and altimeter mounted on the front cabin wall kept passengers informed about their progress. The stewardess pointed out landmarks along the route, and provided blankets and pillows on request.

But despite this surface slickness, much of the experience of flight remained stubbornly discomforting. The noise from the three engines was as deafening as construction work – every passenger was issued with earplugs on boarding. Chairs without shock-absorbers offered no protection against vibrations. The cabins were in principle heated, but the heating system was inefficient and passengers

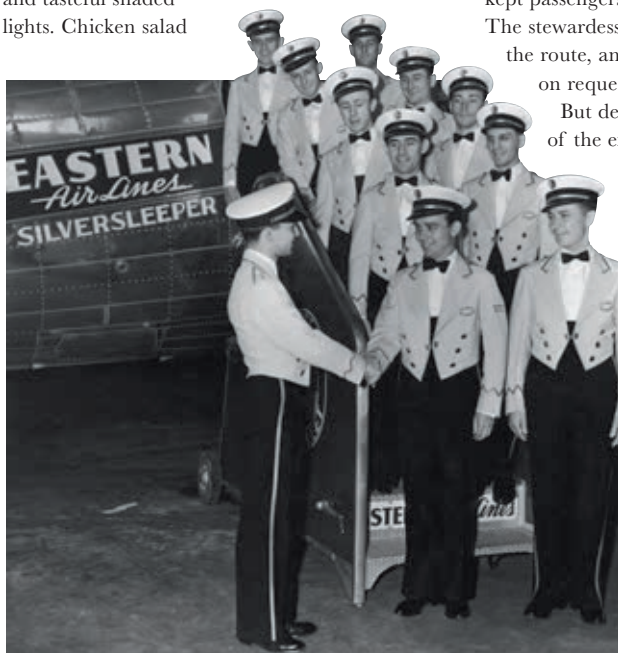


PAN AM WINGS

Pan American Airways hired its first stewards in 1929 and only employed men as cabin attendants until 1944, when it added its first female crew members. The Pan American brand represented adventure and glamour and enjoyed worldwide recognition.

still often wore overcoats. Toilet facilities were initially crude, as one stewardess described: “The toilet was a can set in a ring and a hole cut in the floor, so when one opened the toilet seat, behold, open-air toilet!”

Such minor indignities were nothing compared with the effects of airsickness. Unable to fly above the weather, airplanes frequently gave their passengers a bumpy ride. One of the stewardess's prime tasks was to care for people emptying their stomachs into the coyly named “burp cups” placed under every seat. And at times, having china plates and cups did not seem such a bright idea. Sitting among vomiting passengers and disintegrating crockery, a “bad flight” was as hellish an experience as the worst sea crossing. If the weather was really bad, it was still common in the early 1930s to make emergency landings in cow pastures or on remote emergency airfields. The stewardess's duties might extend to clearing obstacles out of the way for takeoff from an improvised airstrip. Sometimes the stewardess



CABIN CREW

In 1936 Eastern Airlines reverted to male stewards as an economy measure. Stewardesses had to leave their jobs if they married, which most did. A steward gave longer service in return for training.